

The Three-Year Curse

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I've never been able to sit still.

As a rambunctious fifth-grader, my energetic outbursts derailed my class and surely inspired my teachers to drink. As an anxious eighth-grader, I spent more time talking out of turn than I did listening to my teachers, and I became all too familiar with the floors, ceilings, and walls of the front office where I'd wait to be scolded by an assistant principal. Even in high school, when a global emergency forced me into eighteen months of solitary reflection, my histrionic antics persisted and I was voted "Class Clown" by the graduating class of 2023.

I don't know if I'll ever fully suppress the urge to blurt out snarky replies to the simplest of questions, or to pace around the kitchen while holding conversation with seated peers, or to keep my leg from bouncing when I have to sit down for more than five minutes. Maybe someday I will. But who knows?

Even more concerning, I've never been able to stick around the same place for more than three years without being driven to insanity. I spent three years at Santa Fe, one at Village Gate, three at Ocean Knoll, three more at Twin Peaks, and a rare four at Poway High, although the pandemic stole a year and change from me, so it doesn't quite count.

Now I find myself at age twenty, with two Bachelor's degrees from San Diego State, where I first enrolled just yesterday and graduated mere minutes ago, despite my calendar's lie that it has been three years. And I am daunted by the prospect of a six-year doctoral program – Do I really have the patience to stick around in Delaware for just a year less than my high school and undergraduate studies combined? If the prophecy is true, I'll either charge through with lightning efficiency, or fizzle out like a dying star in the clear-skied twilight. *If*.

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I know, as I make my way to the East Coast, that the three-year curse is renewed in my flight. And, once again, I have an opportunity to break this wayward spell. But will I? I guess I'll find out in three years.